

FACING THE GIANTS OF LIFE

INTRO: As we begin this series of sermons I want to make sure everyone is on the same page when we speak of giants in our lives. Giants in our lives are ongoing or systemic problems that seem almost impossible to beat or conquer.

We have all faced giants in our personal, professional and spiritual lives. These giants will either give us a tremendous opportunity to step up to the plate and allow God to be God or they will keep us from being everything God planned for us to be:

- In the best-case-scenario they provide an opportunity for our faith to be tested and grown to maturity...
- In the worst-case-scenario the giants we face have the potential of keeping us defeated in our walk with God...

The upside of giants is that they do amazing things for our prayer lives. (Guy who told me he was “*Sorry for all the trouble he had caused me*” – I told him he had “*Done wonders for my prayer life!*”)

2 Corinthians 10:3-5 (LT) “***We are human, but we don’t wage war with human plans and methods. 4 We use God’s mighty weapons, not mere worldly weapons, to knock down the Devil’s strongholds. 5 With these weapons we break down every proud argument that keeps people from knowing God. With these weapons we conquer their rebellious ideas, and we teach them to obey Christ.***” This Scripture raises the meaning of a giant to a brand new level; the word stronghold here means “*mindset or conclusions contrary to Scripture*” (The battle really is in the mind)

During the course of this study we are going to be using the life of David as a template to

discover what kind of giants we may face in our lives. David faced five giants in the course of his life.

1 Samuel 17:21-24, 41-51 (NKJV) ***“So David rose early in the morning, left the sheep with a keeper, and took the things and went as Jesse had commanded him. And he came to the camp as the army was going out to the fight and shouting for the battle. ²¹For Israel and the Philistines had drawn up in battle array, army against army. ²²And David left his supplies in the hand of the supply keeper, ran to the army, and came and greeted his brothers. ²³Then as he talked with them, there was the champion, the Philistine of Gath, Goliath by name, coming up from the armies of the Philistines; and he spoke according to the same words. So David heard them. ²⁴And all the men of Israel, when they saw the man, fled from him and were dreadfully afraid... ⁴⁰Then he took his staff in his***

hand; and he chose for himself five smooth stones from the brook, and put them in a shepherd's bag, in a pouch which he had, and his sling was in his hand. And he drew near to the Philistine. ⁴¹So the Philistine came, and began drawing near to David, and the man who bore the shield went before him. ⁴²And when the Philistine looked about and saw David, he disdained him; for he was only a youth, ruddy and good-looking. ⁴³So the Philistine said to David, "Am I a dog, that you come to me with sticks?" And the Philistine cursed David by his gods. ⁴⁴And the Philistine said to David, "Come to me, and I will give your flesh to the birds of the air and the beasts of the field!" ⁴⁵Then David said to the Philistine, "You come to me with a sword, with a spear, and with a javelin. But I come to you in the name of the LORD of hosts, the God of the armies of Israel, whom you have defied. ⁴⁶"This day the LORD will deliver you into my hand, and I will strike

you and take your head from you. And this day I will give the carcasses of the camp of the Philistines to the birds of the air and the wild beasts of the earth, that all the earth may know that there is a God in Israel. ⁴⁷“Then all this assembly shall know that the LORD does not save with sword and spear; for the battle is the LORD’s, and He will give you into our hands.” ⁴⁸So it was, when the Philistine arose and came and drew near to meet David, that David hastened and ran toward the army to meet the Philistine. ⁴⁹Then David put his hand in his bag and took out a stone; and he slung it and struck the Philistine in his forehead, so that the stone sank into his forehead, and he fell on his face to the earth. ⁵⁰So David prevailed over the Philistine with a sling and a stone, and struck the Philistine and killed him. But there was no sword in the hand of David. ⁵¹Therefore David ran and stood over the Philistine, took his sword and drew it out of its sheath and

killed him, and cut off his head with it. And when the Philistines saw that their champion was dead, they fled.” 2 Samuel 21:15-22 (NKJV) “When the Philistines were at war again with Israel, David and his servants with him went down and fought against the Philistines; and David grew faint. ¹⁶Then Ishbi-Benob, who was one of the sons of the giant, the weight of whose bronze spear was three hundred shekels, who was bearing a new sword, thought he could kill David. ¹⁷But Abishai (A-bish-e-i) the son of Zeruiah (Zer-a-iah) came to his aid, and struck the Philistine and killed him. Then the men of David swore to him, saying, “You shall go out no more with us to battle, lest you quench the lamp of Israel.” ¹⁸Now it happened afterward that there was again a battle with the Philistines at Gob. Then Sibbechai (Sib-ah-ky) the Hushathite (Who-sha-thite) killed Saph (Saff), who was one of the sons of the giant. ¹⁹Again there was war at Gob

(G-o-b) *with the Philistines, where Elhanan (El-han-non) the son of Jaare-Oregim (J-r-ora-gem) the Bethlehemite killed the brother of Goliath the Gittite (Get-tite), the shaft of whose spear was like a weaver's beam. ²⁰*Yet again there was war at Gath, where there was a man of great stature, who had six fingers on each hand and six toes on each foot, twenty-four in number; and he also was born to the giant.* ²¹*So when he defied Israel, Jonathan the son of Shimea (Shem-e-i), David's brother, killed him.* ²²*These four were born to the giant in Gath, and fell by the hand of David and by the hand of his servants.*”*

We can be sure we will face some of the same giants David faced. As a Christian, the key to overcoming these giants is to identify and defeat them one by one through the power of the Holy Spirit and the Word of God. We may not have all of these evident

in our lives, but chances are at least one has been identified and needs to be dealt with.

I. GOLIATH...

The name *Goliath* means “*To reveal or advertise in a disgraceful sense; reviler; verbal abuser; or gossipier.*” Think about this, what weapon did Goliath use against the men of Israel? Words! The tongue! For forty days he dared them to “***send a man that we may fight together.***” (This is the old maids prayer!!!)

We could say that Goliath is the giant of the untamed tongue. This is probably a giant which all of us face from time to time in varying degrees. It is certainly one of the biggest giants that we will face in our lifetimes.

The tongue is a powerful weapon and can be used for good or evil. Proverbs 18:21

(NKJV) ***“Death and life are in the power of the tongue...”***

- Life – Romans 10:9-10 (NKJV) ***“If you confess with your mouth the Lord Jesus and believe in your heart that God has raised Him from the dead, you will be saved. ¹⁰For with the heart one believes unto righteousness, and with the mouth confession is made unto salvation.”***
- Death – James 3:1-18 (NKJV) ***“My brethren, let not many of you become teachers, knowing that we shall receive a stricter judgment. ²For we all stumble in many things. If anyone does not stumble in word, he is a perfect man, able also to bridle the whole body. ³Indeed, we put bits in horses’ mouths that they may obey us, and we turn their whole body. ⁴Look also at ships: although they are so large and are driven by fierce winds, they are turned by a very small rudder wherever the pilot desires. ⁵Even so the tongue is a***

little member and boasts great things.
See how great a forest a little fire
kindles! ⁶And the tongue is a fire, a
world of iniquity. The tongue is so set
among our members that it defiles the
whole body, and sets on fire the course
of nature; and it is set on fire by hell.
⁷For every kind of beast and bird, of
reptile and creature of the sea, is tamed
and has been tamed by mankind. ⁸But
no man can tame the tongue. It is an
unruly evil, full of deadly poison. ⁹With
it we bless our God and Father, and
with it we curse men, who have been
made in the similitude of God. ¹⁰Out of
the same mouth proceed blessing and
cursing. My brethren, these things
ought not to be so. ¹¹Does a spring send
forth fresh water and bitter from the
same opening? ¹²Can a fig tree, my
brethren, bear olives, or a grapevine
bear figs? Thus no spring yields both
salt water and fresh. ¹³Who is wise and

understanding among you? Let him show by good conduct that his works are done in the meekness of wisdom. ¹⁴But if you have bitter envy and self-seeking in your hearts, do not boast and lie against the truth. ¹⁵This wisdom does not descend from above, but is earthly, sensual, demonic. ¹⁶For where envy and self-seeking exist, confusion and every evil thing are there. ¹⁷But the wisdom that is from above is first pure, then peaceable, gentle, willing to yield, full of mercy and good fruits, without partiality and without hypocrisy. ¹⁸Now the fruit of righteousness is sown in peace by those who make peace.”

An untamed tongue can cause:

- Self-inflicted destruction...
- Destruction inflicted by others... (My conversation with a couple who were spreading untrue, destructive things about me)

The untamed tongue can cause all kinds of destruction in our:

- Job...
- Family...
- Church...
- Friendships...
- Personal life...

What makes the destruction that the tongue can inflict so alarming is that the root of its poison issues out of the heart of the person.

Matthew 12:34-38 (NKJV) ***“Brood of vipers! How can you, being evil, speak good things? For out of the abundance of the heart the mouth speaks.*** ³⁵

“A good man out of the good treasure of his heart brings forth good things, and an evil man out of the evil treasure brings forth evil things.

³⁶***“But I say to you that for every idle word men may speak, they will give account of it in the day of judgment.*** ³⁷***“For by your words you will be justified, and by your***

words you will be condemned.” If we are losing the war against the giant of the untamed tongue, we are showing the world around us a snapshot of our heart, and what is going on within does not make a pretty picture.

The person who is losing the battle against the giant of the untamed tongue often rationalizes this weakness by believing several lies of the enemy:

- You are just opinionated and there is nothing wrong with being an opinionated person...
- If this person did not want this told they should live a better life.
- All we say about our neighbors is true.
- This is just the way you are - don't try to change it.

Before we excuse an untamed tongue in our life we should consider the fact that a

destructive tongue is usually the result of several things:

- Unresolved wounds in ones life...
- Un-restrained bitterness...
- Un-confessed and un-conquered sin...

The person who is always striking out at the weaknesses in others is usually attempting to cover up major failures and judgment lapses in their own life.

Someone said “*Hurting people, hurt people.*” The un-confessed sin of bitterness is a major source of strength for the giant of the untamed tongue.

KEYS TO VICTORY:

Who won the victory over Goliath? David! The name *David* means “*beloved or love.*” He is a type of Christ. Just as David needed the help of the Lord to conquer Goliath, we must have Gods help to conquer the giant of the untamed tongue. What does Gods help

look like with regard to the giant of the untamed tongue? I Corinthians 13:4-8 (NKJV) “*Love suffers long and is kind; love does not envy; love does not parade itself, is not puffed up; ⁵does not behave rudely, does not seek its own, is not provoked, thinks no evil; ⁶does not rejoice in iniquity, but rejoices in the truth; ⁷bears all things, believes all things, hopes all things, endures all things. ⁸Love never fails. But whether there are prophecies, they will fail; whether there are tongues, they will cease; whether there is knowledge, it will vanish away.”*

I believe we must do three things in order to be successful against a powerful giant like the untamed tongue:

- Be in constant communion with God — Ephesians 3:16-19 (NKJV) “*That He would grant you, according to the riches of His glory, to be strengthened with might through His Spirit in the*

*inner man, ¹⁷that Christ may dwell in
your hearts through faith; that you,
being rooted and grounded in love,
¹⁸may be able to comprehend with all
the saints what is the width and length
and depth and height— ¹⁹to know the
love of Christ which passes knowledge;
that you may be filled with all the
fullness of God.”* When we commune

more with God and less with bad influences, the words of our lips will change dramatically. When we are filled up with the life of God rather than being filled with the latest, greatest, juiciest gossip of the day, our conversation will undergo an unbelievable metamorphosis. When we commune more with God and less with the church gossip what we talk about will change because what goes in will come out!

- Allow God to fill us with His power... 1 Samuel 17:32-37 (NKJV) ***“Then David said to Saul, “Let no man’s heart fail***

because of him; your servant will go and fight with this Philistine.”³³ And Saul said to David, “You are not able to go against this Philistine to fight with him; for you are a youth, and he a man of war from his youth.”³⁴ But David said to Saul, “Your servant used to keep his father’s sheep, and when a lion or a bear came and took a lamb out of the flock,³⁵ I went out after it and struck it, and delivered the lamb from its mouth; and when it arose against me, I caught it by its beard, and struck and killed it.³⁶ “Your servant has killed both lion and bear; and this uncircumcised Philistine will be like one of them, seeing he has defied the armies of the living God.”³⁷ Moreover David said, “The LORD, who delivered me from the paw of the lion and from the paw of the bear, He will deliver me from the hand of this Philistine.” And Saul said to David, “Go, and the LORD be with you!” David

knew his power source to deal with Goliath was not in his gene pool; it was vested in the power of God which was in operation in his life.

- Cut off the giant's source of strength...
The power of the tongue is what the mind has been feasting on. Philippians 4:8 (NKJV) ***“Finally, brethren, whatever things are true, whatever things are noble, whatever things are just, whatever things are pure, whatever things are lovely, whatever things are of good report, if there is any virtue and if there is anything praiseworthy—meditate on these things.”*** When we constantly feed our minds on good things our conversation will reflect it. When we feed our mind on unwholesome things our conversation will reflect it.

The giant of the untamed tongue is certainly a formidable force to be reckoned with in all

of us and the Apostle James said “*No man can tame it.*” The only way we can tame the tongue is through the power of God. In fact this is exactly how all of our giants must be dealt with.

II. ISHBI-BENOB... (*Ish-be-be-nob*)

2 Samuel 21:15-17 (NKJV) “*When the Philistines were at war again with Israel, David and his servants with him went down and fought against the Philistines; and David grew faint. ¹⁶Then Ishbi-Benob (*Ish-be-be-nob*), who was one of the sons of the giant, the weight of whose bronze spear was three hundred shekels, who was bearing a new sword, thought he could kill David. ¹⁷But Abishai (*Ab-ish-e-i*) the son of Zeruah (*Zer-a-iah*) came to his aid, and struck the Philistine and killed him. Then the men of David swore to him, saying, “You shall go out no more with us to battle, lest you quench the lamp of Israel.”*”

Please note that just because you have dealt with one giant, does not mean they are all dead! In a perfect world, when you have killed one giant the rest of them leave you alone but this is not a perfect world and the giants just keep coming.

In this scenario, David killed Goliath but once he laid that victory to rest, Ishbi-Benob (Ish-be-be-nob) had to be dealt with. The name means “*My dwelling is on the heights*” or Ishbi-Benob (Ish-be-be-nob) “*I belong above.*” Without doing any injustice to Scripture, I believe we could say Ishbi-Benob (Ish-be-be-nob) represents pride. As soon as Ishbi-Benob’s (Ish-be-be-nob) name is mentioned, the Scripture gives this description of him, “***...The weight of whose bronze spear was three hundred shekels, (11 ¾ Pounds) and he was bearing a new sword.***” Everything about this guy reeks of pride, from being able to throw a oversized spear to the need for carrying a

new sword. The epitome of his pride is proven by this statement, “*He thought he could kill David.*”

The giant of pride manifests itself in many ways throughout our lifetime:

- Pride say’s “*You deserve better...*”
- Pride causes one to stretch the truth...
- Pride causes us to cover our weaknesses and parade our strengths...
- Pride causes us to value and devalue certain relationships based on whether or not they are good for our public persona...
- Pride causes us to run into debt in an attempt to prove we are just as financially successful as the next person...
- Pride say’s “*I had this outfit imported; it is of the finest quality available anywhere in the world...*”
- Pride will cause us to buy a Rolex knockoff in an attempt to make people

think we are wearing the real thing...
The only person who gets deceived in
this scenario is the person wearing the
watch! (We can see the green on your
wrist!!!)

(Guy at Wal-Mart who wanted me to jump
start his car)

The short of it is that pride will cause us to
claim to be something which we are not. It
can even come with such strong delusion
that when others know better, we will
believe its lie ourselves. Pride never
considers whether it will win or lose, it
always operates from an assumption of
victory. Look at what the Scripture has to
say about the giant of pride:

- Proverbs 16:18 (NKJV) “***Pride goes
before destruction and a haughty spirit
before a fall.***”
- Psalms 10:2 (NKJV) “***The wicked in his
pride persecutes the poor; Let them be***

caught in the plots which they have devised.”

- Proverbs 21:4 (NKJV) “*A haughty look, a proud heart, And the plowing of the wicked are sin.*”
- Proverbs 28:25-26 (NKJV) “*He who is of a proud heart stirs up strife, But he who trusts in the LORD will be prospered. ²⁶He who trusts in his own heart is a fool, But whoever walks wisely will be delivered.*”
- 1 John 2:16-17 (NKJV) “*All that is in the world—the lust of the flesh, the lust of the eyes, and the pride of life—is not of the Father but is of the world. ¹⁷And the world is passing away, and the lust of it; but he who does the will of God abides forever.*”

Some Scriptural examples of the destruction which pride is capable of inflicting include:

- Pharaoh... Exodus 5:1-2 (NKJV)
“*Afterward Moses and Aaron went in*

and told Pharaoh, “Thus says the LORD God of Israel: ‘Let My people go, that they may hold a feast to Me in the wilderness.’ ”² And Pharaoh said, “Who is the LORD, that I should obey His voice to let Israel go? I do not know the LORD, nor will I let Israel go.” –

The end result was disaster for the nation and the firstborn died!

- Naaman... (Captain of the King of Assyria) 2 Kings 5:9-12 (NKJV) *“Then Naaman went with his horses and chariot, and he stood at the door of Elisha’s house. ¹⁰And Elisha sent a messenger to him, saying, “Go and wash in the Jordan seven times, and your flesh shall be restored to you, and you shall be clean.” ¹¹But Naaman became furious, and went away and said, “Indeed, I said to myself, ‘He will surely come out to me, and stand and call on the name of the LORD his God, and wave his hand over the place, and*

heal the leprosy.’¹² “Are not the Abanah and the Pharpar, the rivers of Damascus, better than all the waters of Israel? Could I not wash in them and be clean?” So he turned and went away in a rage.” Before he could be healed he was required to deal with pride, humble himself, and wash seven times in Jordan.

- Haman... Esther 3:5 (NKJV) “*When Haman saw that Mordecai did not bow or pay him homage, Haman was filled with wrath.*” Haman was eventually hanged on the very gallows he had built for Mordecai.

Pride is a giant that uses the element of surprise as a masquerade to gain entrance into our lives. Oftentimes this giant has set up a stronghold within us without our even being aware of what has been going on. This is one of the reasons each person needs

an accountability partner who has permission to speak into each of our lives.

Oftentimes, others know pride is present before the individual is aware of what is going on. In the case of an accountability partner they can tell us what they see taking place within us and rather than getting upset with our accountability partner, we deal with the giant that is creating a place of dominance within.

Pride shows up with an oversized spear and a new sword. It is impressive and glitters brighter than a diamond. It often veils itself within a spirit of excellence. A spirit of Excellence is a good thing but if we are not careful there is but one step between a spirit of excellence and demanding or expecting perfection. Demanding or expecting perfection is unreasonable and is couched in a spirit of pride.

Pride has a way of sneaking up on us in new ways throughout our Christian walk. New Christians are not as susceptible to the spirit of pride as seasoned believers are. Pride often follows a great victory or it can surface after a string of victories. When pride is at work we begin to feel superior or invincible.

The battle against pride becomes greater as we get more victories notched on our spiritual belt. It looms greater as we become more skilled at firing our rapid firing gospel gun!

From the time David killed Goliath, he was in a constant battle against the giant of pride:

- Pride caused David to try to kill Nabal... (1Sam 25) Pride is what drives us to attempt vengeance, rather than allowing the Lord to do His job... Deuteronomy 32:35-36 (NKJV) ***“Vengeance is Mine, and recompense; Their foot shall slip in due time; For the day of their calamity***

is at hand, And the things to come hasten upon them.’³⁶ “For the LORD will judge His people And have compassion on His servants, When He sees that their power is gone, And there is no one remaining, bond or free.”

- Pride caused David to commit adultery... (2 Samuel 11) David placed himself above the Law. He knew the woman Bathsheba was married and even knew her husband was one of his most loyal soldiers. Pride caused David to feel it was his right to have anyone he wanted.
- Pride caused David to number the fighting men... (1 Chronicles 21) 70,000 men died by the plague.

Though most of us will battle with the giant of pride throughout our Christian walk, this battle seems to be most severe at certain intervals and these are the times we are most vulnerable:

- Following a great victory...
- Following a series of minor triumphs...
- Following times of success in business...
- Following a time when we have been recognized for certain achievements...
- Following times when our peers have recognized certain strengths in our lives...
- When we are weary from the labor of life and we have let down our guard on the spiritual front...

David could not kill this giant on his own! 2 Samuel 21:15-17 (NKJV) ***“When the Philistines were at war again with Israel, David and his servants with him went down and fought against the Philistines; and David grew faint. ¹⁶Then Ishbi-Benob (Ish-be-be-nob), who was one of the sons of the giant, the weight of whose bronze spear was three hundred shekels, who was bearing a new sword, thought he could kill***

David. ¹⁷But Abishai (A-sish-e-i) the son of Zeruiah (Zer-a-iah) came to his aid, and struck the Philistine and killed him.”

Who helped David in his fight against the giant of pride? “***Abishai*** (A-bish-e-i) ***the son of Zeruiah*** (Zer-a-iah)...” *Abishai* (A-bish-e-i) means “*gift or grace*”, and *Zeruiah* (Zer-a-iah) means “*leprous one*.”

The person who stepped forward was the son of a leper, a gifted man filled with grace, and he was the most unlikely of all to fill this role.

If we are to conquer this giant in our life we will likely need the dynamic of some outside influences at work within us.

(Accountability Partner) James 5:16 (KJV)

“Confess your faults one to another, and pray one for another, that ye may be healed. The effectual fervent prayer of a righteous man availeth much.” The

confession here is about accountability, not forgiveness. God always forgives when we confess to him, but when we confess to an accountability partner we are tied to a new level of responsibility because that person now has permission to ask questions and speak into our lives.

Every person will sooner or later struggle with the giant of pride and it can manifest itself as a superior attitude or on the low side of the scale it can manifest itself as low self-esteem. Romans 12:3 (KJV) ***“For I say, through the grace given to me, to everyone who is among you, not to think of himself more highly than he ought to think, but to think soberly, as God has dealt to each one a measure of faith.”*** 1 Corinthians 10:12 (KJV) ***“Therefore let him who thinks he stands take heed lest he fall.”***

KEYS TO VICTORY:

Who won the victory over Ishbi-Benob?
This time it was not David but Abishai (Abish-e-i), the warrior who became a “*gift of grace*” in David’s life. When faced with the giant of pride, this is what we must do:

- Realize we are unable to conquer this giant solo... Zechariah 4:6 (NKJV)
“This is the word of the LORD to Zerubbabel: ‘Not by might nor by power, but by My Spirit,’ Says the LORD of hosts. ⁷ ‘Who are you, O great mountain? Before Zerubbabel you shall become a plain! And he shall bring forth the capstone With shouts of “Grace, grace to it!”
- Realize God has provided sources of strength in the day of our battle... If we are to be successful against the giant of pride we can ill afford to go it alone, God and others are essential to defeating this enemy.
- Relinquish our rights to privacy... Privacy is the hotbed of Satan! He uses

secrecy in his battle against the child of God. If we learn to bury our faults and failures rather than confessing them he will have us believing we are the only ones in the world who are struggling with these issues. Getting our faults and failures out in the open destroys the giant of pride and accelerates the healing and deliverance of the believer.

III. SAPH...

2 Samuel 21:18 (NKJV) “*Now it happened afterward that there was again a battle with the Philistines at Gob. Then Sibbechai (Sib-e-ky) the Hushathite (Who-sha-thite) killed Saph (Saff), *who was one of the sons of the giant.*” The name *Saph* (Saff) means “*double faced*” or in our culture “*two faced*.” If we knew a person to be two-faced we would not hesitate to identify that person and their character as one of hypocrisy. Saph then is the giant of hypocrisy.*

Though our culture does not readily recognize it as such, hypocrisy is deception and is therefore a form of lying. The world's system lends itself to each person developing a public persona and a private persona.

Integrity occurs when an individual's life is in harmony with God and their public persona and private persona are one and the same.

The Scripture ramps up the language on this subject:

- The Apostle John had some straightforward comments on this subject... 1 John 2:1-6 (NKJV) “***My little children, these things I write to you, so that you may not sin. And if anyone sins, we have an Advocate with the Father, Jesus Christ the righteous.² And He Himself is the propitiation for***

our sins, and not for ours only but also for the whole world. ³Now by this we know that we know Him, if we keep His commandments. ⁴He who says, “I know Him,” and does not keep His commandments, is a liar, and the truth is not in him. ⁵But whoever keeps His word, truly the love of God is perfected in him. By this we know that we are in Him. ⁶He who says he abides in Him ought himself also to walk just as He walked.”

- Jesus’ statements on this subject are very blatant... Matthew 7:15-23 (NKJV)

“Beware of false prophets, who come to you in sheep’s clothing, but inwardly they are ravenous wolves.” ¹⁶“You will know them by their fruits. Do men gather grapes from thornbushes or figs from thistles? ¹⁷“Even so, every good tree bears good fruit, but a bad tree bears bad fruit. ¹⁸“A good tree cannot bear bad fruit, nor can a bad tree bear

good fruit. ¹⁹“Every tree that does not bear good fruit is cut down and thrown into the fire. ²⁰“Therefore by their fruits you will know them. ²¹“Not everyone who says to Me, ‘Lord, Lord,’ shall enter the kingdom of heaven, but he who does the will of My Father in heaven. ²²“Many will say to Me in that day, ‘Lord, Lord, have we not prophesied in Your name, cast out demons in Your name, and done many wonders in Your name?’ ²³“And then I will declare to them, ‘I never knew you; depart from Me, you who practice lawlessness!’”

Much of the modern day church world has been deceived into believing a life of hypocrisy is acceptable. We have been told we can have:

- Access without accountability...
- Blessings without bearing responsibility...

- Christ likeness without convictions...
- Deity without duty...
- Earth without eternity...
- Failure without being fined...
- Goodness without Godliness...
- Honor without requiring holiness...
- Influence without integrity...
- Jesus without judgment...
- Kindness without the king...
- Love without the Lord...
- Marriage without monogamy...
- A new birth without neutering the nature of the old man...
- An open heaven without an open heart...
- Passion without prayer...
- Quality without questions...
- Religion without relationship...
- A savior without confessing sin...
- A treaty without truth...
- Unction without uprightness...
- Victory without being valiant in battle...
- Worship without a righteous walk...

- Experience without exactitude...
- Yahweh without yielding to His directives...
- Zion without zeroing in on the ways of God...

The problem with Hypocrisy is that it allows us to continue living our sinful life without ever having to confront the real issue: A life un-surrendered to God.

Hypocrites are like double-agents; becoming who they want to be depending on the situation. (Lady who wanted to be Susan's armor-bearer, but would be repeated as saying nasty hateful things)

Hypocrites are like viruses that infiltrate the body through deception or covert action and when they are granted entrance, they take over. Hypocrites are:

- Bad for business...
- Bad for marriage...

- Bad for friendships...
- Bad for church life...

KEYS TO VICTORY:

Saph, the two-faced giant was killed by Sibbechai (Sib-e-ky). The name *Sibbechai* (Sib-e-ky) means “*Corpse like.*” Those who conquer this giant must know what it means to be dead to self and dead to the need for applause and accolades. They must also do the following things:

- Kill the old man... Romans 6:2-14 (NLT) “*Since we have died to sin, how can we continue to live in it?* ³ *Or have you forgotten that when we became Christians and were baptized to become one with Christ Jesus, we died with him?* ⁴ *For we died and were buried with Christ by baptism. And just as Christ was raised from the dead by the glorious power of the Father, now we also may live new lives.* ⁵ *Since we have been united with him in his death, we*

will also be raised as he was. ⁶ Our old sinful selves were crucified with Christ so that sin might lose its power in our lives. We are no longer slaves to sin. ⁷ For when we died with Christ we were set free from the power of sin. ⁸ And since we died with Christ, we know we will also share his new life. ⁹ We are sure of this because Christ rose from the dead, and he will never die again. Death no longer has any power over him. ¹⁰ He died once to defeat sin, and now he lives for the glory of God. ¹¹ So you should consider yourselves dead to sin and able to live for the glory of God through Christ Jesus. ¹² Do not let sin control the way you live; do not give in to its lustful desires. ¹³ Do not let any part of your body become a tool of wickedness, to be used for sinning. Instead, give yourselves completely to God since you have been given new life. And use your whole body as a tool to do

what is right for the glory of God. ¹⁴ Sin is no longer your master, for you are no longer subject to the law, which enslaves you to sin. Instead, you are free by God's grace."

- Break the chains that tie us to the old life... Hebrews 12:1-2 (NLT)
"Therefore, since we are surrounded by such a huge crowd of witnesses to the life of faith, let us strip off every weight that slows us down, especially the sin that so easily hinders our progress. And let us run with endurance the race that God has set before us. ² We do this by keeping our eyes on Jesus, on whom our faith depends from start to finish. He was willing to die a shameful death on the cross because of the joy he knew would be his afterward. Now he is seated in the place of highest honor beside God's throne in heaven."

- Stay away from hypocrites... 1 Corinthians 15:28 (NLT) “***Bad company corrupts good character.***”
- Guard against deception of any kind... 1 Thessalonians 5:22 (NKJV) “***Avoid the very appearance of evil.***” Romans 12:2 (NLT) “***Don’t copy the behavior and customs of this world, but let God transform you into a new person by changing the way you think. Then you will know what God wants you to do, and you will know how good and pleasing and perfect his will really is.***”
- Live to Christ... Galatians 2:20 (NLT) “***I myself no longer live, but Christ lives in me. So I live my life in this earthly body by trusting in the Son of God, who loved me and gave himself for me.***”

IV. LAHMI... (La-hom-e)

2 Samuel 21:19 (NKJV) “***Again there was war at Gob (G-o-b) with the Philistines, where Elhanan (El-han-non) the son of***

Jaare-Oregim (J-air-ora-gem) **the Bethlehemite killed the brother of Goliath the Gittite** (Get-tite), ***the shaft of whose spear was like a weaver's beam.***” In this passage of Scripture we are not introduced to Goliath's brother by name, only by the description of his weapons. However, in 1 Chronicles 20:5 we are given his name. 1 Chronicles 20:5 (NKJV) ***“Again there was war with the Philistines, and Elhanan (El-han-non) the son of Jair (J-air) killed Lahmi (La-hom-e) the brother of Goliath the Gittite (Get-tite), the shaft of whose spear was like a weaver's beam.”***

The name *Lahmi* (La-hom-e) means “*Full of food, lustful or sensual.*” Lahmi (La-hom-e) is the giant of lust or sensuality. This giant is predominant in our day. In this culture lust is not something that is looked upon as a thing that one should be ashamed of, it is paraded all day, every day, across our television sets, on billboards, in shopping

malls, and has even found its way into the church.

In my opinion, this has become such a problem in our culture. Our children have become desensitized to the evils of a lust-filled lifestyle. As a result they have learned behavior patterns that have led them down a road that promotes sensual behavior. This has happened in our own homes, before our very eyes, the enemy has taken charge of many households without any resistance whatsoever.

This lifestyle has become so accepted in this culture that it has become fashionable to live in such a way, even in the church. It is a crying shame that when we come to church we find it necessary to worship with our eyes closed, not because we are focusing on Jesus but because we do not want to be distracted by the dress, or lack of it, of those around us! (My wife's grandmother wears

more to bed than some people wear to church! – I was going to preach on the clothes line but I could not find enough material)

I have often wondered as I see some of the teenagers in such sensual looking clothing, *“How did they get out of the house in such a state of undress?”* Then I see their parents and it is abundantly clear, a monkey see, monkey do philosophy is at work in the home.

Christians would do well to remember:

- As a rule, parishioners will live more loosely than their Christian leaders... Leaders should feel the responsibility to set the standard!
- The morals of our children will be more lax than ours... If we want our children to stop at a certain point we must position the stop sign a few feet before

the intended destination, they WILL run past the stop sign!

- What we allow to go on in our house will eventually be going on in Gods house... As goes the home, so goes the church! Whatever we allow in our homes, our children will eventually allow at church!

This is not a problem that is unique to the laity; it has found its way into the home of the ministers as well.

It has come to the point that many ministers' wives are so scantily clad, or wear such tight fitting clothing that you cannot tell them from the clubbing crowd! One thing I appreciate about my sweet wife is that she has never embarrassed me by her appearance in public, and I would hope that would be an encouragement to some of the rest of you to get dressed in a modest outfit before you come to church!

We do not come here to see how many curves you have. We are here to worship Jesus! Besides that, some of you have more curves than the road going to Pikes Peak and we do not care to see it!

When the giant of lust or sensuality is able to gain entrance into our lives it will not be satisfied with a small out-of-the-way place, it will develop “*A spear, like a weavers beam*” which it will effectively use against us in its quest to dominate everything about us!

A Weavers beam was made of steel and could stand much resistance. This giant is no ordinary foe; he comes equipped and ready for battle as well as prepared to go the distance.

The root of lust and all sinfulness is selfishness! The giant of lust operates in

selfishness and only considers what is pleasing to self. Philippians 3:17-21 (CEV)
“My friends, I want you to follow my example and learn from others who closely follow the example we set for you. ¹⁸ I often warned you that many people are living as enemies of the cross of Christ. And now with tears in my eyes, I warn you again ¹⁹ that they are headed for hell! They worship their stomachs and brag about the disgusting things they do. All they can think about are the things of this world. ²⁰ But we are citizens of heaven and are eagerly waiting for our Savior to come from there. Our Lord Jesus Christ ²¹ has power over everything, and he will make these poor bodies of ours like his own glorious body.”

This giant is responsible for the depravity of the world and has destroyed many mighty men. The giant of lust destroyed the destiny of the following people:

- Adam & Eve... Introduced sin into the world.
- Saul... His lust was for power.
- David & Bathsheba...
- Solomon... Could not leave the ladies alone. Being a leader and a womanizer do not mix.
- Samson... He allowed his lust for a woman to override his better sense of Judgment. Lust ruined his life.
- Demas... *“Demas has forsaken me, because of his love for this present world...”*

The giant of lust causes a thinking problem. It causes a person to be unable to have their minds focused on productive things or spiritual things because it is constantly attempting to drag our minds into the gutter. It attempts to cause us to focus on temporal pleasures rather than on spiritual things or things which would allow us to make a

larger contribution to the well being of ourselves and others.

The symptoms of being controlled by the giant of lust include:

- Thoughts or acts of fornication...
- Thoughts or acts of adultery...
- Sexual perversion...
- Pornography...
- Homosexuality...
- Gluttony...
- Unhealthy pursuit of wealth...
- Unhealthy pursuit of acceptance...

We may say within ourselves, *“I dodged the bullet on this one; I saved myself for marriage; I have been completely faithful to my marriage partner; I do not participate in acts of sexual deviance; I am not attracted to pornography; I am strictly heterosexual; I eat a balanced diet; and I am not greedy of the things this world offers; I do not go to*

unacceptable lengths to be accepted by people!” If all these things were true, this is still no indication we have completely killed the giant of lust! Listen to the words of Jesus. Matthew 5:27-28 (KJV) ***“Ye have heard that it was said by them of old time, Thou shalt not commit adultery: ²⁸ But I say unto you, That whosoever looketh on a woman to lust after her hath committed adultery with her already in his heart.”***

KEYS TO VICTORY:

2 Samuel 21:19 (NKJV) ***“Again there was war at Gob with the Philistines, where Elhanan (El-han-non) the son of Jaare-Oregim (J-are-ora-gem) the Bethlehemite killed the brother of Goliath the Gittite (get-tite), the shaft of whose spear was like a weaver’s beam.”*** Elhanan (El-han-non) killed the brother of Goliath. The killing of Goliaths brother certainly did not get the press coverage the killing of Goliath received; this victory was none-the-less

important and noteworthy. The name “*Elhanan*” (El-han-non) means “*God is gracious.*” We can rest assured; anyone who has a tussle with the giant of lust will need the grace of God in order to prevail. When the grace of God enters the picture of our battle against lust it brings with it several important factors that will be necessary in any successful fight against this enemy:

- Positive thoughts... Lust thrives in an atmosphere of random, uncontrolled thoughts. Philippians 4:8 (NKJV)
“Finally, brethren, whatever things are true, whatever things are noble, whatever things are just, whatever things are pure, whatever things are lovely, whatever things are of good report, if there is any virtue and if there is anything praiseworthy—meditate on these things.”
- Contentment... Lust is born out of a perceived need for something that we do

not already have. Philippians 4:11-13 (NKJV) *“Not that I speak in regard to need, for I have learned in whatever state I am, to be content: ¹²I know how to be abased, and I know how to abound. Everywhere and in all things I have learned both to be full and to be hungry, both to abound and to suffer need. ¹³I can do all things through Christ who strengthens me.”* Our focus should be on what we have rather than what we do not have. Perhaps we could state it even better by saying we should focus on what God wants us to have rather than what we want to have. Having God in our lives should be over the top for all of us. *“He’s all I need...”* *“Take this whole world but give me Jesus...”*

- Rejoicing behavior... Lust is incubated in a life that fails to celebrate the favor and gifts of grace along the way. 1 Thessalonians 5:18 (NKJV) *“In every*

thing give thanks: for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus concerning you.

- Rest... A life of lust is marked by restlessness. Restlessness is a sure sign that lust is at work. When the grace of God enters the picture God resets our desires to reflect the wishes of His Grace. Being at rest means we have ceased to struggle against the known will of God, and have decided to allow God to bring out His higher purpose in us. This is a giant we cannot kill on our own; this battle requires the help of the Lord! When we recognize this and turn the battle over to the Lord He has committed Himself to providing the power to kill the giant of lust! Philippians 2:13 (CEV) ***“God is working in you to make you willing and able to obey him.”***

V. THE UNNAMED GIANT...

2 Samuel 21:20-21 (NKJV) ***“Yet again there was war at Gath, where there was a man of great stature, who had six fingers on each hand and six toes on each foot, twenty-four in number; and he also was born to the giant. ²¹So when he defied Israel, Jonathan the son of Shimea (Shem-e-i), David’s brother, killed him.”*** In this Scripture we are introduced to a giant that in addition to being a man whose stature is imposing, has six fingers on each hand and six toes on each foot. Though we are not made aware of his name, the descriptive language in this verse, points to a fearless man who has a powerful grasp and tremendous sense of balance. (The first time I met Susan’s grandfather he noticed I had oversized feet and he said. *“You would have been really tall if God had not turned so much under for a foundation.”*

As a result of this giant’s unique physical features, once this giant is able to get his

hands around a victim he rarely feels the need to release his victim; his focus is on moving in for the kill.

I think we could say, this unnamed giant represents greed.

One of the great problems with greed is that it never allows for a place of contentment in life. Philippians 4:11-13 (NKJV) “***Not that I speak in regard to need, for I have learned in whatever state I am, to be content: ¹²I know how to be abased, and I know how to abound. Everywhere and in all things I have learned both to be full and to be hungry, both to abound and to suffer need. ¹³I can do all things through Christ who strengthens me.***”

One of the greatest things in life is being able to find a comfort zone, so to speak, in which one can live and be able to enjoy the trip through life. Greed interrupts such a life

and never allows any semblance of normalcy to return.

Greed is closely associated with Idolatry. When greed begins its conquest of a person's life, it shoves to the side all sense of reason and sets wealth and power up as a thing to be worshipped instead of God! Greed is an idolatrous practice!

The need for possessions and power develops a culture of enslavement that causes the affected person to live in a fog of deceit that has a tendency to skew reality. The person who is affected cannot conduct an honest assessment of where they really are.

Look at what the Word of God has to say about greed:

- Greed is a trap... 1 Timothy 6:9 (NKJV)
“But those who desire to be rich fall into temptation and a snare, and into

many foolish and harmful lusts which drown men in destruction and perdition.” If I told you that the isles of this church had land mines in them, how many of you would use an isle to exit the building? Not one of you; every single person would climb over a chair to exit the building. The Scripture has made it clear that greed is a trap that should be avoided.

- Greed is cast on the same level as worshipping idols... Colossians 3:5 (NKJV) ***“Therefore put to death your members which are on the earth: fornication, uncleanness, passion, evil desire, and covetousness, which is idolatry.”*** If I were to announce this morning that we are going to get together in this Sanctuary at 6:00 tonight and we are going to worship the U.S. flag, not one of you would show up, and there would be a groundswell of support demanding my resignation and you

would be right to do so. Yet, because of our materialistic culture, we worship at the altar of greed on a daily basis and no one seems to say anything.

- Greed angers God... Colossians 3:5-6 (NKJV) ***“Therefore put to death your members which are on the earth: fornication, uncleanness, passion, evil desire, and covetousness, which is idolatry. ⁶Because of these things the wrath of God is coming upon the sons of disobedience.”*** Who in their right mind wants to tick God off? (Story of little boy who overheard his parents discussing the theft of the statue Mary being taken from the Catholic Church... He told his friend, “*Someone has kidnapped God’s mother and they think we had something to do with it!*”)
- Greed is the root of all evil... 1 Timothy 6:10 (NKJV) ***“You can have mo“For the love of money is a root of all kinds of evil, for which some have strayed from***

the faith in their greediness, and pierced themselves through with many sorrows.” “You can have money without loving it and you can love money without having it.” I personally know more people who do not have it, but love it, than I know people who have it and love it. Someone said, “People who say that ‘money cannot buy happiness’ do not know where to shop!”

- Greed creates internal and external conflicts... James 4:1-4 (NKJV) ***“Where do wars and fights come from among you? Do they not come from your desires for pleasure that war in your members? ²You lust and do not have. You murder and covet and cannot obtain. You fight and war. Yet you do not have because you do not ask. ³You ask and do not receive, because you ask amiss, that you may spend it on your pleasures. ⁴Adulterers and adulteresses! Do you not know that friendship with***

the world is enmity with God? Whoever therefore wants to be a friend of the world makes himself an enemy of God.” You can be assured that when a person or persons are driven by greed there will be a litany of internal and external conflicts that will develop on an ongoing basis!

Let us take a moment and look at how the giant of greed destroyed some Biblical characters that were intended to be great for God:

- Jacob... His need for things caused him to deceive his brother Esau. The astounding thing is that his mother aided and abetted him in his pursuit of wealth. This act separated his family for decades and almost ruined their lives altogether.
- Judas... Lusted for acceptance and a path to popularity. Money was a part of this as well, but it turned out to be the least of the motive.

- Ananias and Sapphira... They lied to the Apostle Peter so they could keep the proceeds of the sale of their land, which had been dedicated to God.

Greed will cause people to do things they never thought they would do:

- Greed has caused honest people to compromise their principles...
- Greed has caused the breakup of otherwise strong marriages...
- Greed has caused many young children to be dragged through the court system while greedy adults try to decide who will be in control...
- Greed has brought down people who spent a lifetime developing a reputation of honesty and integrity...
- Greed has pronounced jail sentences upon people who did not believe they were capable of doing what they were accused and found guilty of...

- Greed has caused the collapse of fortune 500 companies that should have remained strong and taken care of those who worked to build it... (ENRON)

Greed is a giant which all of us would do well to guard against.

KEYS TO VICTORY:

2 Samuel 21:20-21 (NKJV) ***“Yet again there was war at Gath, where there was a man of great stature, who had six fingers on each hand and six toes on each foot, twenty-four in number; and he also was born to the giant. ²¹So when he defied Israel, Jonathan the son of Shimea (Shem-e-i), David’s brother, killed him.”***

Jonathan, David’s nephew conquered the giant of greed. *Jonathan* means “*Jehovah has given.*” Once greed has seized an individual, no one but God can cause the individual to be able to assess their situation and deliver them from the grip of this giant.

As we fight against this giant of greed we would do well to keep our focus on three things:

- Pursue God as the number one priority in life... Matthew 6:33 (NKJV) ***“But seek first the kingdom of God and His righteousness, and all these things shall be added to you.”***
- Develop a spirit of giving... 1 Timothy 6:17-19 (CEV) ***“Warn the rich people of this world not to be proud or to trust in wealth that is easily lost. Tell them to have faith in God, who is rich and blesses us with everything we need to enjoy life. ¹⁸ Instruct them to do as many good deeds as they can and to help everyone. Remind the rich to be generous and share what they have. ¹⁹ This will lay a solid foundation for the future, so that they will know what true life is like.”***

- Trust God and use things, rather than placing our trust in things and using God... Matthew 6:25–34 (CEV) ***“I tell you not to worry about your life. Don’t worry about having something to eat, drink, or wear. Isn’t life more than food or clothing? ²⁶ Look at the birds in the sky! They don’t plant or harvest. They don’t even store grain in barns. Yet your Father in heaven takes care of them. Aren’t you worth more than birds?²⁷ Can worry make you live longer? ²⁸ Why worry about clothes? Look how the wild flowers grow. They don’t work hard to make their clothes.²⁹ But I tell you that Solomon with all his wealth wasn’t as well clothed as one of them. ³⁰ God gives such beauty to everything that grows in the fields, even though it is here today and thrown into a fire tomorrow. He will surely do even more for you! Why do you have such little faith? ³¹ Don’t worry and ask***

yourself, “Will we have anything to eat? Will we have anything to drink? Will we have any clothes to wear?”³² Only people who don’t know God are always worrying about such things. Your Father in heaven knows that you need all of these.³³ But more than anything else, put God’s work first and do what he wants. Then the other things will be yours as well.³⁴ Don’t worry about tomorrow. It will take care of itself. You have enough to worry about today.”